be able to concentrate on the most important thing, the ball coming towards me.

Commit and watch the ball.

I wanted to be decisive. I wanted my battle to be not with myself, but with the opposition collectively and the bowlers individually. I couldn't go on being stuck in the crease, neither forward nor back, not committed to a defensive shot or an attacking flourish. I was half-hearted, unresponsive and unsatisfied.

Bawds asked me to expand on my feelings, to explain what I experienced when I was at my most confident. I answered flippantly but revealed a central truth. I felt most secure in bed, the night before an innings. It was my refuge; nothing could get me there. Though Alice stayed with me from time to time, I was usually alone. There were no distractions.

I felt at peace, savoured the silence. It was the lull before the storm. Bawds stimulated my imagination by suggesting that in those moments of respite I should start to write down who I wanted to be, what I wanted to do, the following day. How did I want to bat, knowing that the nerves would still be there, nibbling at my stomach lining? The sense of liberation was immediate.

I just want to score runs.

I want to be able to clear my mind, so I can concentrate on the ball.

I want to be decisive, go out there with my shoulders back.

I want to leave the ball well.

I want to fight.

Bawds told me to go through the checklist when that dread came over me. I added technical details to the mantra, relating to individual bowlers and distinctive situations. To give a specific example, I reminded myself to open up to an inswinging bowler, to concentrate on hitting the ball in certain areas, rather than being obsessed by playing straight.

It may sound almost pedestrian, but it worked for me. Two days later, I scored a century in the Adelaide warm-up game and felt renewed. Sometimes I would read the piece of paper containing my inner thoughts, screw it up and throw it in the bin. Other times I would take it to the ground, secrete it in my kit and study it when those familiar doubts began to bite.

Psychologically, Bawds felt I had forgotten what made me successful. My immediate response was to suggest my unnecessarily flawed technique